

An Autistic Young Child in Your Activity

For toddler/activity-class leaders, swimming & gym teachers & sports coaches — supporting an autistic pre-school child (roughly ages 2-5).

The one idea

Autism, through **monotropism**, means a young child's attention is pulled into a few deep, intense "tunnels" at a time. Activity settings — echoing halls, whistles, bright lights, sudden changes, "everyone find a partner!" — are genuinely hard for a monotropic child, *even one who loves to move*. The good news: a few predictable, sensory-kind adjustments (the same warm-up, a quiet corner, one instruction at a time) make participation possible and joyful. At this age the goal is simple — a child who **wants to come back next week**.

What you may see — and what's really going on

You may see...	What's often happening
Won't join in; clings; runs off	Overload from noise, novelty and demand — not naughtiness
Meltdown or goes floppy/silent mid-session	Involuntary response to sensory overload or a sudden change
Deeply absorbed in one piece of equipment	Monotropic focus — a strength to build on, not a distraction
Doesn't hear the whistle; "ignores" you	When absorbed, things outside the tunnel don't register
Upset by the buzzer, the echo, the bright lights	Sensory hyper-responsiveness — real discomfort, not fussiness

Try this

- **Same warm-up, same routine every session** — predictability lowers the entry cost.
- **Show, don't just tell** — demonstrate the skill; give **one short instruction at a time** with a moment to process.
- **Lower sudden noise** — hand signals, quiet claps; warn before a whistle or buzzer; allow ear-defenders.
- **Offer a quiet corner and a signal** to step out; never punish stimming or movement.
- **Build the relationship first** — a child who trusts you will push through more; celebrate effort and the interest.

Avoid this

- Surprise changes, loud sudden sounds, or "everyone watch me!" pressure.
- Stopping the child stimming, moving, or using a comfort object.
- Reading a freeze or a run-off as defiance rather than overload.

When to get more support

If a child is frequently overwhelmed, partner with the parent — they know the triggers and early signs. A predictable structure, a sensory-friendly space and supportive peers are the evidence-based facilitators for autistic children's physical activity. Keep the goal wellbeing and confidence, not performance.

If the child is a girl

Girls this age camouflage early and may be missed; a quiet, compliant surface can hide real overload. Watch for withdrawal as much as for meltdowns.

About this guide

*AI-assisted, derived from this project's research drafts — **Growing Up Monotropic** (Part 4, sports & coaching) and the **Monotropism** brief. Uses identity-first language. **Informational — not a diagnostic tool.** Fit it to the individual child.*

Key sources. Murray, Lesser & Lawson (2005); Murray, F. (2023); Michaud & Harvey (2025, physical-activity scoping review); Dwyer (2025). Full citations are in the source drafts.